

Tong Ru

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PROFILE

Ph.D. candidate in Administrative and Policy Studies with over 10 years of experience in education policy research, program evaluation, and evidence synthesis for international development. Specialized in experimental and quasi-experimental methods for education interventions, quantitative analysis, systematic literature reviews, and translating complex research into policy-relevant outputs.

EDUCATION

University of Pittsburgh Pittsburgh, the United States
Ph.D. in Administrative and Policy Studies (Economics track) Expected May 2026
Dissertation Committee: Dr. Najeeb Shafiq (Advisor); Dr. Xu Qin (Co-advisor);
Dr. Daniel Jones; Dr. Sean Kelly

- Dissertation: Promoting Human Capital Development of Children in Rural China: Three Empirical Studies within the Education Production Function Framework

- Creativity-related Non-cognitive Development of Children in Rural China: A Machine Learning and Mixed-Method Study
- Does Ethnicity Matching Matter? Evidence from Tibetan Teachers and Tibetan Students in Rural China
- Causal Mediation Analysis on an Early Childhood Development Intervention in Rural China

- Core Coursework: Economics of Education; Behavioral and Experimental Economics; Economics of Social Policy; Causal Inference in Social Science Studies; Natural Language Processing with Python; Data Programming with Python & R.

Shaanxi Normal University

Xi'an, China

M.Sc. in Labor Economics

June 2017

- Thesis: Impact of Parental Migration on Academic Outcomes of Left-Behind Children in Rural China (Difference-in-Difference regression method)

- Core Coursework: Econometrics, Development Economics, Program Impact Evaluation, Methods of Social Investigation, Data Analysis using Stata, Research on Social Development Theory and Education, Article and Policy Brief Writing.

Xi'an Technological University

Xi'an, China

B.Eng. in Materials Chemistry

July 2013

- Core Coursework: Advanced Mathematics, Linear Algebra, Probability Theory and Mathematical Statistics.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

UNESCO Regional Office, Bangkok

Jan–Jul 2024

Education Intern (Policy and Program Support)

- Co-developed the Education Simulation Model for Cambodia's Education Strategic Plan (ESP) 2024–2028.
- Supported regional and national SDG 4 mid-term review process, analyzing education indicators, and drafting monitoring reports.
- Supported the Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE) Simulation Model for ASEAN Countries; drafted research reports and policy briefs.
- Contributed to education finance modeling and policy analysis.

UNICEF China, Beijing

Jun–Aug 2023

Social Policy Intern

- Supported Public Finance Management and Governance projects.
- Analyzed 20 years of China's public education spending data; created visualizations and identified trends in education equity and resource allocation.
- Coordinated child-targeting stakeholder workshops and co-authored policy briefs on education finance.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE	Center for Experimental Economics in Education, Xi'an	2017–2020
	<i>Research Assistant</i>	
	- Led and coordinated field experiments, survey design and implementation, and data analysis. - Engaged with local governments and NGOs for project collaboration. - Drafted grant proposals, program reports, and policy briefs.	
	University Center for International Studies, Pittsburgh	2022–2023
	<i>Graduate Assistant</i>	
	- Coordinated leadership development programs, tracked impact assessment.	
	Asian Studies Center, Pittsburgh	2021–2022
	<i>Program Coordinator</i>	
	- Coordinated university-wide student connection program. - Managed program website and social media. - Trained student ambassadors and implemented student assessment.	
	RCT: Village-based Parenting Center for Children Aged 0–3 in Rural China	
	June 2016–Present	
	- Causal inference analysis for a longitudinal ECD study; led evaluation strategy and measurement design.	
	Community-based Support for Early Learning and Responsive Care	
	Nov 2023–Aug 2024	
	- Designed survey tools; analyzed impacts of ECD programs across 40 counties in Southwest China.	
	RCT: Computer-Assisted Learning (CAL) Program in Rural China	
	Jul 2019–Dec 2024	
	- Supervised project in 200+ schools in rural northwest China; responsible for field coordination, data collection, and report writing.	
	Discipline construction: Human Capital Development in Western China	
	Sep 2016–Dec 2019	
	- Drafted grant proposal and program reports. - Designed the building strategy of the Experimental Economics in Education (EEE) discipline and research platform.	
	Health Information Intervention in Rural Tibetan Areas of China	
	May 2016–Dec 2016	
	- Supervised project implementation in 58 schools; responsible for field coordination, data collection, and report writing.	
	RCT: Reduce Malnutrition and Improve Infants' Development	
	Aug 2014–May 2015	
	- Designed tools and protocols; led training and supervision for data collection with rural families across 100 villages in rural northwestern China.	
	RCT: Conditional Cash Transfer (CCT) and Maternal-Child Health Uptake	
	Aug 2014–Dec 2014	
	- Designed surveys and supervised field teams across 27 minority villages in rural minority areas of China.	
	RCT: Vision Care Program in Rural Schools	May 2014–Jun 2015
	- Designed questionnaires; trained enumerators; managed data collection and supervision across 300 schools in rural northwestern China.	

PUBLICATIONS

1. **Tong Ru**, Xu Qin, Ai Yue. (2026). Causal Mediation Mechanisms Underlying Early Childhood Development Interventions in Rural China. Accepted, *Child Development*.
2. Yueming Cao, Dan Wang, Yu Bai, **Tong Ru**. (2024). Effect of ethnic stereotype threat on academic performance: Experimental evidence from rural China. *China Economic Review*, 86, 102204.
3. Ai Yue, Yali Zhang, Shuhang Zhao, Shibin Liang, **Tong Ru**, Na Qiao, Yaojiang Shi. (2024). The effect of paternal parenting behaviors on children development in western rural China. *Journal of Asian Economics*, 92: 101736.
4. **Tong Ru**. (2023). How To Reduce Educational Inequality Between Urban and Rural Regions in China: Evidence from Field Experiments. *Written Response to the Comparative and International Education Society (CIES) 2023 Annual Conference*.
5. Yu Bai, Michael Neubauer, **Tong Ru**, Yaojiang Shi, Kaleigh Kenny, & Scott Rozelle. (2020). Impact of Second-Parent Migration on Student Academic Performance in Northwest China and its Implications. *The Journal of Development Studies*, 56:8, 1523–1540.
6. Yaojiang Shi, Linxiu Zhang, Fang Chang, Han Liu, Bin Tang, Qiufeng Gao, Hongyu Guan, Jingchun Nie, Jie Yang, Yu Bai, Ying Li, Lei Tang, Ai Yue, & **Tong Ru**. (2020). Practices and Experiences of Randomized Controlled Trials in China’s Targeted Poverty Alleviations in Education. *Journal of East China Normal University (Educational Sciences)*, 38(8): 1–67. (in Chinese)
7. Wenbin Min, **Tong Ru**, & Yaojiang Shi. (2019). The Impact of Childhood Poverty Experience on Rural Youth’s Non-cognitive Ability—From the Perspective of the Life Course Theory. *Contemporary Education Forum*, 5: 90–98. (in Chinese)

WORKS UNDER REVIEW

1. **Tong Ru**, Yaojiang Shi. Understanding Human Capital Development in Rural China: Comparative Insights from the Education Production Function in Developing Countries. Under review at *Journal of East China Normal University (Educational Sciences)*.

WORKING PAPERS

1. Parental investment, School Choice, and Persistent Benefits of Early Childhood Intervention in Rural China.
2. Using Curiosity to Promote Caregivers Visiting the Parenting Center: Evidence from A Field Experiment in Rural China.

TEACHING INTERESTS

- **Economics of Education**: including Labor Economics, Human Capital Theory, and Education Production Function Framework.
- **Quantitative Methods in Educational Research**: including Causal Inference, Causal Mediation Analysis, Experimental Design, Quasi-Experimental Analysis, Data Analysis using Python, R, and Stata.
- **Education Policy Evaluation and Analysis**: including rigorous methods for assessing effectiveness of educational policies and interventions, and analysis on the practical implementation of educational policies and interventions.
- **Seminar on Child Development and Family Engagement**: focusing on methodological tools and practical applications, and the critical evaluation of classic literature and recent empirical studies.

PRESENTATIONS How UN Agencies Promote Education Initiatives: Case Studies of UNICEF and UNESCO

- Invited Presentation at the International Forum on Rural Education and Evidence-based Research, Xi'an, China, June 2024

Ingroup or Outgroup: Will Tibetan Teachers Benefit Tibetan Students More Than Han Teachers?

- Oral Presentation at the 2023 Annual Conference of Comparative & International Education Society, Washington, D.C., February 2023

Education in Rural China: A General Description using Contemporary Chinese Village Gazetteer (CCVG) Dataset

- Invited Presentation at the Conference on Rural Society and Politics in China, University of Pittsburgh, Pittsburgh, April 2022

Understand the Creativity Development of Children in Rural China: A Mixed-Method Study

- Oral Presentation at the 2022 Annual Conference of Comparative & International Education Society, Minneapolis, April 2022

Order Matters: The Effect of Second-Wave Migration on Student's Academic Performance in Northwest China

- Oral Presentation at the Hayami Conference, Graduate Institute for Policy Studies, Tokyo, Dec 2017

- Oral Presentation at the Chinese Economist Society (CES) Annual Conference, Shenzhen, Jun 2016 (with Michael Neubauer).

**JOURNAL
REVIEWS**

- *Australian Journal of Agricultural and Resource Economics*
- *BMC Health Services Research*
- *PLOS One*

**SCHOLARSHIPS
& AWARDS**

- School of Education Merit Scholarship, University of Pittsburgh 2026
- Asian Studies Dissertation Scholarship, University of Pittsburgh 2024-2026
- China and Chinese Studies Tuition Remission Scholarship 2023-2024
- Graduate Student Assistant Fellowship, University of Pittsburgh 2022-2023
- China and Chinese Studies Tuition Remission Scholarship 2021-2022
- Institute for International Studies in Education Award 2021
- Comparative & International Education Studies Award 2021
- Global Asia Tuition Remission Scholarship, University of Pittsburgh 2020-2021
- Outstanding Graduate Student, Shaanxi Normal University 2017
- First-class, Ji Xue Scholarship, Shaanxi Normal University 2016
- Second-class, Ji Xue Scholarship, Shaanxi Normal University 2015
- Third-class, Ji Xue Scholarship, Shaanxi Normal University 2014
- Third-class, Academic Scholarship, Xi'an Technological University 2013
- Second Prize, National English Competition for College Students 2011
- Outstanding Volunteer, Xi'an China International Horticultural Exposition 2011
- Second Prize, National English Competition for College Students 2010
- Second-class, Academic Scholarship, Xi'an Technological University 2010
- Academic Scholarship in English, Xi'an Technological University 2010

SKILLS & COMPETENCIES	• Research & Analysis: Experimental design (RCTs), quasi-experimental methods (DID, IV, RDD), causal mediation analysis, systematic literature reviews, evidence synthesis • Data Management & Visualization: Large-scale dataset processing, statistical analysis, data visualization for policy audiences • Programming & Software: Python, R, Stata (advanced); Github, HTML, Markdown, & webpage editing • Writing & Communication: Policy briefs, research reports, technical documentation, academic publications; experience writing for diverse audiences including policymakers, practitioners, and academics • Project Management: Multi-site field coordination, stakeholder engagement, remote collaboration across time zones, and timely delivery	
LANGUAGES	Chinese: Native language English: Professional working proficiency Japanese: Basic communication skill	
MEMBERSHIP	Association for Asian Studies Comparative & International Education Society Chinese Economists Society	November 2021/Present April 2021/Present June 2016/Present